

Session 17: Macro-Level Repetition in Biblical Poetry

Key Takeaways

- In biblical poetry, the authors invite us to compare parallel words/images in lines that are not next to each other through the use of symmetry (e.g., a symmetrical design such as ABBA).
- The biblical authors often employ wordplay using graphically similar words in Hebrew to convey relationships and meaning.

Poetic Conventions in Ancient Israel

Poetry is a form of speech that achieves a unique balance of maximum communication and ambiguity at the same time.

“If we could hear God talking, making his will manifest in words of Hebrew language, what would it sound like? Poetry is our best human model of intricately rich communication. It’s not only solemn, weighty, and forceful, but also densely woven with complex internal connections, meanings, and implications. It makes perfect sense why divine speech in the Hebrew Bible is most often represented as poetry. ... The form of this divine poetry helps explain why these texts have touched the lives of millions of readers far removed in time, space, and situation from the small groups of ancient Hebrews who produced and first read these texts.”

Alter, Robert (2011). [*The Art Of Biblical Poetry*](#). Basic Books. 141.

Recommended Resources

Here is a starter’s bibliography on biblical poetry.

- J.P. Fokkelman, [*Reading Biblical Poetry: An Introductory Guide*](#).
- Robert Alter, [*The Art of Biblical Words*](#).
- Adele Berlin, [*The Dynamics of Biblical Parallelism*](#).
- F.W. Dobbs-Allsop, [*On Biblical Poetry*](#).

Larger Levels of Symmetry and Parallelism in Biblical Poetry

The biblical poets employ symmetrical parallelism in “multiple dimensions,” so to speak. They can invite the reader to compare parallel words/images that are next to each other in the text sequence, but they can also signal that words/images should be compared with a parallel in a text that is distant. This signal is called symmetry. The poetic lines are given a symmetrical design so that the reader notices parallels in non-juxtaposed lines.

Symmetry Between Individual Poetic Lines

- A If I forget you Jerusalem
B let my right hand wither.
B Let my tongue stick to my palate
A if I don't remember you.

Psalms 137:5-6. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

- A Yahweh frustrated the plans of the nations;
B he reduces to nothing the schemes of the peoples.
A Yahweh's plan endures forever,
B the schemes of his heart, from generation to generation.

Psalms 33:10-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

- A Love the Lord,
B all you his godly ones!
C The Lord preserves the faithful
C and fully recompenses the proud.
A Be strong and let your heart take courage,
B all you who hope in the Lord.

Psalms 31:23-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Symmetry Between Parts of a Stanza (Group of Poetic Lines)

- A Hear, my son, and **accept** **my sayings**
and the years of **your life** will be many.
-
- B I have **directed** you **in the way of wisdom** ;
I have **led** you **in upright paths** .
-
- B' When you **walk** , your **steps will not be impeded** ;
and if you **run** , **you will not stumble** .
-
- Take hold** **of instruction** ;

A' do not let go.
Guard her, for she is **your life**.

Example of Biblical Poetry Structure. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Symmetrical Design of an Entire Poem

May God be gracious to us and **bless us**
and make his face **shine (יֵאֵר)** upon us. Selah

That your ways may be known in **the land** ,
your salvation among **all nations** .

May **the peoples** praise you, O God;
may all **the peoples** praise you.

May **the nations** be glad and sing for joy,

for you rule **the peoples** with justice

and guide **the nations** of the land. Selah

May **the peoples** praise you, O God;
may all **the peoples** praise you.

Then **the land** will yield its harvest,
and **God**, our **God**, will **bless us** .

May God **bless us** ,
that all the ends of the land might **fear (יִירָאוּ)** him.

Psalms 67. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

This pattern invites the reader to compare and contrast lines that are parallel and distant from one another.

The poem begins by calling upon God in the language of the blessing of Aaron from [Numbers 6:24-26](#).

A comparison of symmetrically matching lines yields a deeper layer of meaning in the poem.

The opening and closing lines call for God’s blessing upon Israel, but for what purpose? The final line makes clear that God’s blessing serves a larger purpose, namely, so through Israel all the nations will come to recognize the power and authority of Yahweh.

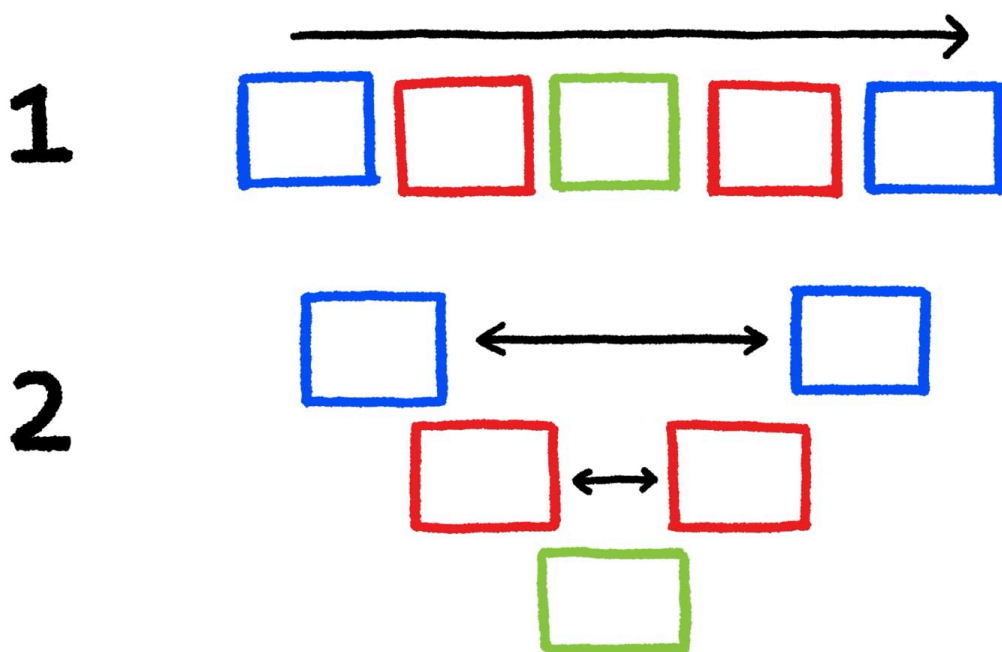
This same theme is carried deeper by the next pair of lines: Yahweh’s “ways” and “salvation” are to be made known in all the land. How, exactly? By the land producing such a rich harvest of divine blessing that they will be forced to acknowledge Israel’s God.

The refrain in the center of the poem makes clear that Israel’s blessing fits into a wider purpose that all nations come to honor Yahweh the way that Israel does.

The poem’s central lines focus on this theme. It’s a request for the nations to experience the same divine presence and blessing that Israel does by Yahweh bringing justice and his royal rule to bear upon them.

This entire poem, therefore, is a poetic meditation on the role of God’s promise to Abraham that through his seed God’s blessing might be restored to all the nations. The symmetrical parallelism fosters and increases the visibility of this theme.

DIFFERENT WAYS OF READING



Different Ways of Reading. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Reflection Question

Repetition can occur between poetic lines and also between larger chunks of text called stanzas. What are some practical ways to help you notice when repetition occurs between stanzas? What do you think this kind of repetition contributes to the meaning of a poem?